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Before NYC was a Major Slave Market, Freedmen from Africa Were Allowed to Own Farmland

JULY 7, 2015 BY PENELOPE BAREAU (*adapted*)

A stranger on horseback in 1650 riding up a road in Manhattan might have noticed black men working farmland near the Hudson River. It was not an unusual¹ sight, and if he remarked on it at all to himself, he would have thought they were simply slaves working their masters' land. But no—these were freedmen² working land they personally owned and had owned for six years. It was land in what is now the Far West Village and it had been granted³ to eleven enslaved men along with their freedom in 1644.



In 1626, the year Manhattan was formally settled by the Dutch, these eleven African men had been rounded up in Angola and Congo and shipped to the New World to work as slaves clearing land and building fortifications. We know they were from there because the manifests of Dutch ships list them with names such as Emmanuel Angola and Simon Congo.

Under the Dutch, slaves built a fort, a mill, and new stone houses. They broadened⁴ an Indian trail and turned it into Broadway; and they worked the farms of the Dutch owners, planting, harvesting and managing them when the owners were away. The rules governing slavery allowed men to own land and to work for themselves in their spare time. Little by little, by hard work, talent and good luck, some Africans had been able to acquire small lots of land. Some were men whose owners had freed them, believing they had put in their time. Some were men who had been able to buy their freedom and then some land. An area of what is now Greenwich Village was occupied by some of these small “free Negro lots.”

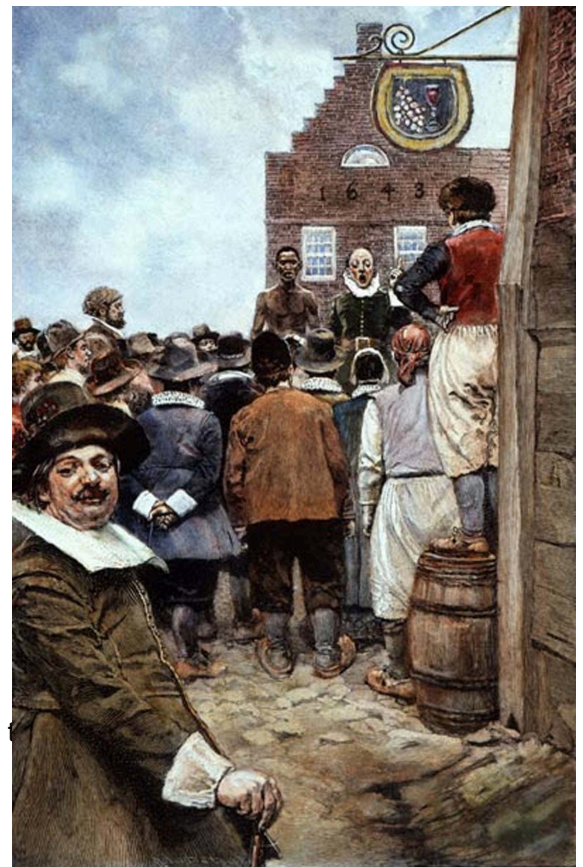
In 1644, the eleven men petitioned the Dutch West India Company for their freedom and that of their

¹ Unusual: unfamiliar or uncommon

² Freedmen: slaves who had been freed by their masters or bought

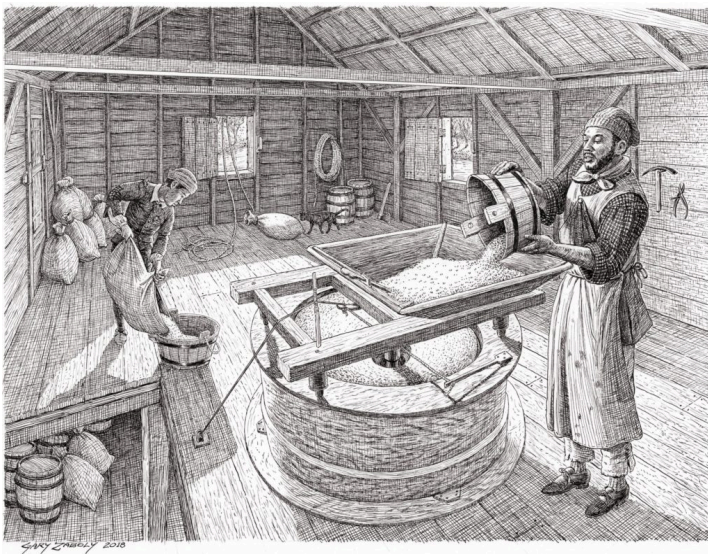
³ Granted: given to

⁴ Broadened: to make wider



families, and they were granted it along with some land. Their wives were also granted freedom, but not their children, although eventually they were able to buy their children's freedom. One of these eleven men, Emmanuel Angola, married a woman brought from Africa, Maria, and became a landowner and father. They are the ancestors⁵ of Christopher Moore, a historian, writer and a former Landmarks Preservation commissioner well known for his role in securing preservation⁶ of the African Burial Ground in Lower Manhattan. In his 1998 book he says his ancestor Big Man "loved to whittle⁷" wood and that family history had been passed down in the twelve generations since Big Man's time by word of mouth and notations⁸ in a family bible.

But by 1664, the English eventually had invaded and conquered the Dutch, renaming their acquisition New York. This was not good for the Africans, for the English rescinded⁹ many of their rights, including the right to own land, and they lost their property in 1712. Not only that, but the Duke of York awarded port privileges in New York to slave ships because he was a principal investor in slave trafficking; the city became a major slave market in the beginning of the 18th



century. The market was located at the present-day corner of Wall and Pearl Streets, and by the year 1700, 750 of the city's 5,000 people were slaves. This number would increase by several thousand in the coming years. Enslaved people were used in plantations throughout the city's boroughs and became essential to the construction of large manor houses, such as the Van Cortlandt House and Morris and Pelham estates in the Bronx. Slave labor produced food and products that made the colonial landholders increasingly wealthy and were a key factor behind New York City's success.

⁵ Ancestors: family members from a long time ago

⁶ Preservation: to maintain in good condition or same condition

⁷ Whittle: make small wood carvings with a knife

⁸ Notations: Small markings or notes

⁹ Rescind: to take back; to cancel or repeal